Kerala, clearly a reward for dancing to the political tunes to oust K Karunakaran from the Chief Minister's chair using the ISRO spy case.

Now that the CJM had given him a favourable order, Senkumar expected me to challenge it in the high court. I refused to fall into this trap. Instead, I went to the Supreme Court, challenging not the CJM's order that gave permission for further investigation, but the Balakrishnan-Patnaik order that upheld the government order for further investigation. I filed a special leave petition on 20 December 1996, praying for quashing of the high court order and, thereby, the Kerala Government's executive order.

The battle was now in the final stage. My co-accused Sasi, Chandra and Sharma joined in as petitioners. Having decided to fight to the finish, together we employed a battery of lawyers including Harish Salve, K K Venugopal and T S Arunachalam. S Muralidhar, who later became a judge of the Delhi High Court, was my lawyer on record. The Kerala Government brought in Advocate General M K Damodaran, besides Shanti Bhushan who was rumoured to be charging Rs 1.25 lakh per appearance.

Salve, who later became the Solicitor General of India, was a busy lawyer. So busy that he would hold conversations with different people at the same time. Or so I thought. During a discussion about the case, I found Salve preoccupied by too many things. I was talking, and he kept humming in reply to my sentences while poring over some other papers and attending phone calls. As a scientist, I was used to people listening intently and focusing on one thing a time.

'Mr Salve, are you listening?' I said.

He looked up from the files.

'You may be good at multitasking,' I continued, 'but I demand your full attention when I am talking to you.'

I was as surprised as the lawyer was, when I finished the sentence.

Salve looked at me for a moment, then said, 'Okay. You have seven minutes of my uninterrupted attention.'

He listened in silence as I broke into a speech, capturing the essence of the case right from the sexual frustration of an inspector that led to the arrest of Maldivian woman Mariam Rasheeda to the CBI report that had